Aimee

By Mary Beth Miller

ZOE: I don't know if I can [talk] about what happened and come out whole – alive. I don't know if I can look back. Besides, if I tell it, who will listen? No one believes us – the kids, that is. They all think we have it so great and that this is the best times of our lives. When people tell me that, I want to puke. If this is the best time of my life and I'm going to spend the rest of my life looking back at this, then I should just end it all right now. *(long beat)* Oh, Aimee, I didn't mean that. . . I'll start with the way it was. . .

INTRODUCTION

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ZOE: She stared out the window and blew a long trail of smoke that floated from her lips to her hair, then spread into the air, thin curls of smoke heading for

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the crack in the window. *(to Aimee)* Is it worse lately?

AIMEE: What?

ZOE: You know

AIMEE: Say it.

ZOE: *(to audience)* I froze, unable to speak and stared at her. Even then I couldn't say the important things. I couldn't face ugly truths. Aimee had never really been explicit about what happened in her house. She dropped hints, but she never said outright what was going on. She and her stepmother didn't get along, that I knew. In front of people, her stepmother was as nice as sugar, but I had always known she abused Aimee. But now, as I looked at Aimee's eyes – her cheeks – her shaking hands, I wondered if I knew anything.

AIMEE: What do you want to know? The details?

ZOE: No, Aimee. I thought she knocked you around. Hit you, stuff like that.

AIMEE: Yeah, she does if I don't do what she says.

ZOE: Does she say mean things?

AIMEE: Don't all parents?

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ZOE: Aimee, don't you want to talk about it?

AIMEE: You know what I want to talk about? I want to talk about my cat. And you know what? No one wants to talk about her. 'She's just a cat.' 'You can get another one.' No one says 'Wow! You and that cat go back a long way. She remembers what it was like before, when your real mother lived with you, when your dad didn't walk around with blinders on, when you knew you were safe in your own bed. She slept with you night after night . . . soothing you even when your parents fought. And when your mother left? When she ran off? Did your cat try to tell you that everything would be okay? Did she act like nothing bad had happened? Tell me that!

ZOE: *(to audience)* She stopped, her shrill voice echoing. She looked at me for a long time before she fell against me and cried. I rubbed my hands up and down her back. She rocked with me a while, then she stiffened.

AIMEE: *(stiffening)* Don't touch me.

ZOE: Her voice came from some inner place I had never glimpsed. *(to Aimee)* What does she do to you,

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Aimee. Tell me. *(to audience)* She needed to say it. Her eyes were hollow, empty of feeling. There was something dead inside her, something cold and frozen that never felt the heat of anything. She hid it most of the time. But it was the only thing in her eyes when I asked my question.

AIMEE: Nothing that unusual. Lots of girls do it. It helps them when they get married.

ZOE: *(to audience)* She sounded strange, so far away – not in distance, but in time. She sounded young, childlike. Images I'd never dreamed of tumbled from her lips, of her stepmother and her . . . "games." "Games" she called it when Aimee was young, then "preparation." Now she used threats – that she'd tell Aimee's dad about it, that she'd touch her brother like that. Threats Aimee knew were real. Because Aimee had seen her destroy her family, had seen her drive her mother away across the county, had seen her steal her brother's affection from her, had made Aimee into a problem child for her father. And all the while her

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stepmother remained an icon of her church, her community her family.

No one would believe Aimee. Not a soul. Things like that don't happen. Things like that never happen, especially in families like theirs. There was no physical proof. There wouldn't be semen to test for. Was there any way to test for female stuff? Secretions? Probably, but that would mean telling, and Aimee's empty face told me that she wasn't going to do that. *(to Aimee)* So what do we do?

AIMEE: What I've been trying to do all along. Die.

ZOE: *(to audience)* My mind always stops when I remember her simple response . . . "Die." It's too hard to face. I didn't have the energy for this, not tonight, not ever. I pulled the spread off the other bed and covered her up. "Sleep," I said. I turned off the light and lay down on the empty bed. Her breathing slowed, then became inaudible. She fell asleep. I climbed under the covers of my bed and allowed myself to sleep . . . . .

I woke to see Aimee creeping back into the room.

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AIMEE: I'm scared. I'm scared . . .

ZOE: Everything will be fine.

AIMEE: I don't think I could have come this far without you as my friend. Will you stay with me tonight? One last time?

ZOE: *(to audience)* Something inside me jerked awake, something I had let sleep – warning lights, sirens, bells, everything started clambering in my jittery mind. *(to Aimee)* What do you mean, Aimee? One last time?

AIMEE: I need to end it, and I can't. Not without your help. Not without you here. It's so dark and scary doing it alone.

ZOE: No, Aimee. Not that. You're my best friend. I can't live without you. I'll help you live . . . not here . . . if that's what you want. I'll support you any way I can. Tell them I've seen her come for you. Tell them I've seen her beat you. Tell everyone about what happened until they believe it, but I need you alive. Aimee, your dad will be home tomorrow, and we're going to tell him what's going on. You won't have to tell him, I will. I'll support you one hundred percent.

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AIMEE: Then support me how I want you to support me. I can't do it your way. I'm tired. Tired of everything . . . I have to sleep. But you have to stay with me so I can do this.

ZOE: No, I will not help you kill yourself. *(to audience)* I still didn't at that point have much of a clue about what exactly she was talking about. Did she mean help her slice her wrists? Hold her hand while she did? Watch her die? I'd check the bathroom for razors now. *(to Aimee)* I'm going to the bathroom.

AIMEE: Bring me the bottle on the sink . . . I want to take something.

ZOE: *(to audience)* My mouth went dry. Drier than when she had asked me to help her die . . . *(to Aimee)* What bottle?

AIMEE: Bottle on the sink. Very important. Stepmother should never leave sleeping pills out with kids in the house. Never. *(Aimee laughs, a deep gagging laugh)*

ZOE: *(to audience)* I raced for the bathroom. I thought I just needed to hide the bottle, that she hadn't taken anything or done anything. The mirror over the

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sinks had been shattered. Mixed with the mirror's shards were pieces of the drinking glass – she must have thrown it at the mirror. I also saw fragments of what appears to be family photo albums. Every picture of her stepmother had been cut into tiny fragments. There were no pictures of Aimee anywhere. But the bottle was there. I was almost unaware of my tears as I picked it up . . . There was no rattle of pills. *(calls out)* Aimee! *(to audience)* She had already taken the pills. I felt devoid of hope. *(calls out)* Aimee! *(to audience)* . . . I need to get to Aimee. I needed to get help.

(calls out) Aimee! *(to audience)* She wasn't answering. She was lying face down on the bed. Her back rose, fell, rose, fell, but slowly . . . too slowly. I rolled her over and came face to face with despair. A long trail of vomit slithered down the side of the bed. I had planned on making her throw up, but she already had. It was the only thing I knew to do that would slow things down and get some of the drugs out of her system. *(to Aimee)* Oh

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God! Oh God! . . . Aimee! How much of this stuff did you take? Answer me! Answer me! *(to audience)* But she didn't. She couldn't. *(to Aimee's lifeless body)* Damn you! Damn you for this! *(to audience)* I raised her head, tried to support her with my shoulder while I cradled her from behind. I tried to make her vomit again. That's when her bladder let go. Later, I learned that this is a normal part of death when someone takes sleeping pills.

I was screaming, shrieking, moaning. I thought someone would hear me. Some jogger, somebody walking a dog. I couldn't see the clock. Couldn't let go of Aimee. She was gurgling now, and I thought I should lay her down. My screams weren't even making Aimee twitch. I screamed on and on, and eventually, when Aimee's eyes were fixed and dilated, when she was cold and blue and filthy and beginning to stiffen up in my arms, someone heard. There was a pounding on the door, but I would have had to let go of Aimee to let them in. And I couldn't. I just kept screaming, incoherent rages

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against God and county, and everyone in between . . . *(in anguish)* She's dead. She's dead. Aimee's dead.

(to audience) I quit screaming. I waited. I slipped away. I stopped thinking, stopped reacting like a human being. I became still, cold, dead inside. I still feel that way most of the time. . . .

I can't say mad at Aimee. I want to, but I can't. She was, is, my friend, and he needed far more than I could give her. I couldn't or wouldn't understand what she needed – so maybe's she's wherever she is now, screaming silent screams of anger back at me because I didn't help her . . . But I was scared . . . scared of every sad and angry word she said. It terrified me to imagine her in a coffin and dead and not on the other end of the phone when I needed to talk. So I didn't think it could happen.

Friends don't commit suicide. They don't die.

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